

Gen O

born with a digital spoon

What will life be like for the first generation of humans that have always had technology around them?

Robert Sovereign-Smith
editor@thinkdigit.com

There's a documentary film called Generation Zero, about what caused the US recession. This has nothing to do with that. Our Gen O is, well, for all practical purposes, the Facebook and Google generation. The first generation to grow up with technology all around them, woven seamlessly into their lives. The smartphone generation, the iPad kids, the Internet babies... you get the drift.

If you're reading this magazine, you have to exclude yourself from this exclusive club of city-born, decently well-off, exposed to technology from birth...err... babies. It's the generation that's being named after Googling "baby names", whose parents watch YouTube videos to learn how to change diapers, or how to correctly burp a baby. Internet parenting at its very best. OK, perhaps I exaggerate a little by generalising, but I've seen it happen around me.

When we conceptualised the idea of "Tech Reborn", we thought about how technology is changing, and how it's adapting to our usage patterns, how it's weaving itself into the very fabric of our lives, etc. For now, before we think of

going down that road, we have to first look at how technology is changing us... not just as individuals, but also as a society in general.

My digital valentine

The tech savvy are using technology for absolutely everything. Internet marriages are hardly uncommon these days, even in our rather conservative society. Indian's are hooking up online, date, go out, and some eventually get married. Soon no one will sit and reminisce about the "good old days" – waiting in line to pay utility bills, or transfer money. Heck, we wouldn't even visit malls anymore if it wasn't for the fast food courts and the chance to fraternize with the opposite gender – we can work, be entertained, socialise, learn, shop... all at home. There's no real reason to go out anymore in a true digitally-thinking culture.

However, we're also blending and merging into this one large amalgamate of boring sameness. What romantic stories will we tell the next generation about how we met our significant others – an ad on a marriage portal, love at first sight on Facebook, or perhaps at a tech

store, where you helped her choose the right router for her home?

Again, I exaggerate; but isn't that where we're headed eventually?

Social networking – the end of society as we know it

Yes, I know we harp on about this often enough, but there's a reason. It's not like you couldn't chat with others right since the earliest days of the Internet. IRC, ICQ, bulletin boards, etc, were all about sharing information. All the IM services that followed were all just precursors to what we see now. However, being anonymous was key then, and being known is key now. Learning and enhancing skills was important then, socialising and becoming semi-famous the goal now.

Take a look at Twitter. It's a wonderful tool for quick breaking news, sharing something with your followers, or quickly adding an insight to a current topic. How many of us use it that way though? All we end up seeing is individuals who try to be witty, or comment on as many topics as possible, with no real insight. We re-tweet interesting looking posts without even opening the URLs

